A Question of Trust

The big idea

A Question of Trust by **Victor Canning** is about **Horace Danby**, a respectable-looking burglar who is himself **tricked by a cleverer thief**. The story is full of **irony**: the man who robs others trusts a stranger and is robbed of his freedom.

Summary

- **Horace Danby:** About fifty, unmarried, respectable, a skilled **locksmith** with a small business. He loves **rare and expensive books**. To buy them, he **robs one safe every year**, planning carefully, and then lives honestly for the rest of the year.
- **The plan:** This year his target is **Shotover Grange**, whose safe holds jewels worth about **£15,000**. He has studied the house for weeks; the family is away and the servants are at the cinema. He knows the dog and has made friends with it.
- **Inside the house:** He suffers from **hay fever**, and the flowers in the house make him sneeze. As he begins on the safe, a voice from the door asks what he is doing. A **young, pretty woman in red** appears, pretending to be the **lady of the house**.
- **The trap:** She says she could call the police but would rather not, as he seems a gentleman. She claims she needs her jewels to wear and has forgotten the safe's combination. She charms him; he takes off his gloves and opens the safe for her, leaving **fingerprints** everywhere.
- **The arrest:** A few days later, the police arrest Horace for the jewel theft. His fingerprints prove it. No one believes his story about the lady, because the real lady of the house is much older. The young woman was **another thief**.

- **In prison:** Horace works as the **prison librarian** and keeps thinking about that charming woman who made a fool of him.

THE IRONY IN THE TITLE

Horace, a thief, wanted to be trusted by the woman; but he trusted her, and she betrayed him. "There is honour among thieves" proves false.

Character of Horace Danby

- Respectable in appearance, skilled, careful, a planner.
- Lover of rare books — his weakness that leads to crime.
- **Over-confident and gullible** — taken in by charm and flattery.

THE WOMAN DID NOT CALL THE POLICE

She pretended to spare him from the police; he was caught later through his **fingerprints**.

Themes and value points

- Crime does not pay; every crime leaves a trace.
- **Do not trust strangers blindly**, especially when appearances are charming.
- Dishonesty, even for "good" hobbies, is wrong.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why did Horace rob a safe every year? How did the lady trick him? What was the irony? Why didn't anyone believe his story? Character sketch of Horace.

Quick recap

- Victor Canning; Horace Danby, locksmith, robs one safe a year to buy rare books.
- Shotover Grange; jewels worth £15,000; hay fever.
- Lady in red tricks him into opening the safe without gloves.
- Arrested by fingerprints; becomes prison librarian — "a question of trust".

Practice questions

1. Why did Horace Danby rob a safe every year?
   (a) To pay his debts (b) To help the poor (c) To buy rare and expensive books (d) To travel abroad
2. What was Horace's profession?
   (a) Banker (b) Locksmith (c) Librarian (d) Policeman
3. Which health problem troubled Horace in the house?
   (a) Asthma (b) Fever (c) Headache (d) Hay fever
4. How did Horace get caught?
   (a) His fingerprints were found on the safe (b) The lady called the police at once (c) The dog bit him (d) A servant saw him
5. Who was the young woman in red?
   (a) The lady of the house (b) A police officer (c) Another thief (d) Horace's niece
6. What job did Horace do in prison?
   (a) Cook (b) Guard (c) Gardener (d) Assistant in the prison library
7. "A Question of Trust" is a story of irony. Discuss.

Answers: 1. c 2. b 3. d 4. a 5. c 6. d 7. see notes